

# Awareness of Language and Learning: Vietnamese Immigrants Navigate Bilingualism in the New Culture

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## Abstract

The present report of research on language learning compares two groups of immigrants from Vietnam who settled in Taiwan in some ways under similar circumstances, and in other ways very different. While both groups faced the task of learning or improving their proficiency in Mandarin Chinese, the second group, of the present study, were all speakers of another language of the Chinese family of languages. In this report, we mainly consider the task of second language learning of Mandarin and literacy learning as part of the process of transition toward new citizenship. The participants in the project are representative of populations that were part of multi-cultural societies in their home country. In particular, the experience of the bilingual immigrants in the present study includes already having attained literacy in Chinese. Their experience of integration is qualitatively different from that of all non-Chinese-speaking immigrant populations, and is important to study as it presents itself as an important contrast, in particular in regard to the factor of language awareness. The comparisons and contrasts between these two immigrant populations from Vietnam we hope will serve in part as a template for better understanding the experience of other immigrant groups.

## Keywords

Cantonese – Mandarin – second language learning – metalinguistic awareness – cross-cultural understanding

## 1 Introduction

In East Asia, language contact and multilingualism have accompanied the movement of populations and cultures in interesting ways, in different ways for each country in modern times, more profoundly for kingdoms and dynasties in ancient times. Taiwan and Mainland China are not alone among the countries of the region that in the coming years will be receiving increased numbers of immigrants (Tsay, 2015), often under precarious conditions.<sup>1</sup> As an important factor affecting the successful integration of new residents, citizens-to-be, our project has singled out for study the factor of language learning, both for the immigrants themselves and for their first generation (G1) host country-born children.

For better understanding the stages of adaptation in each case, it is important to compare the widely varying circumstances of language contact and interaction. The first example that we considered was the learning of Chinese as a second language (L2) by speakers of Vietnamese, typically as monolinguals. This was the language learning scenario of the previous study mentioned in the Abstract (cohort 1). Because of a shared linguistic and literary history, learners from this immigrant population appeared to be able to draw on their first language (L1) and first culture as a useful resource for learning Chinese. The relevant factors of cultural learning may present themselves as parallel to language learning, or they may be more independent. In regard to this varying relationship between language and culture, readers can consult the study of cultural and social identity of Vietnamese immigrants in Taiwan by Yu (2014). In addition to the observation of extensive linguistic parallel between Vietnamese and Chinese, knowledge of cultural frameworks has also been the object of study by social scientists as an example of a broad-based cultural affinity with roots reaching deep into a shared history of thousands of years.

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1 A large number of ethnic Chinese refugees from Northern Vietnam fled to Guangxi and Yunnan provinces during the war of 1979, and illegal cross-border trafficking from Vietnam's border provinces with China continues to the present day (Liang & Chen, 2014; Liang, 2018). Demographic tendencies drive much of the migration to the advanced economies of East Asia, Taiwan being one of the most visible examples (Chang, 2019).

As the Yu study suggests, because immigrants perceive important degrees of compatibility in outlook and expectation between Vietnamese and Chinese culture, this perspective might explain the hypothetically greater tendency toward integration within different domains beyond just language learning, greater than that for other immigrant groups.

The relationships of linguistic “closeness” and “distance” are often difficult to make precise, but in the case of learning Chinese as a L2 by L1 speakers of Vietnamese, some of the relationships, in particular those involving long term historical ties, are evident even to the untrained eye and ear. On the one hand, there is the example of the existence of common features of grammar, phonology and shared lexicon (Alves, 2001). Then, we can consider the learning of Mandarin Chinese as the national/official language by speakers of other Chinese languages/dialects. This is the language learning scenario of the present study (cohort 2). Comparing the learning situation in these two scenarios will contribute to our understanding of immigrant adaptation and integration in general. In this paper, we are proposing that these factors are applicable at some level to all groups of newcomers who are L2 learners. Especially instructive it will be to study the case of L2 Chinese learning, including literacy (in particular), by learner populations that do not appear to benefit from the above-mentioned advantages of linguistic and cultural prior knowledge. In addition, the learning challenges are sometimes compounded by complex motivational factors. See Li & Chuk (2015) for one example.

Thus, the over-arching goal of our project, over the long term, is to compare and contrast the different circumstances of successful second language learning with learning scenarios that are less successful, *especially in regard to L2 literacy in Chinese*. From one point of view, the literacy learning question appears as unremarkable, as its implications seem obvious, related to the prospects, for non-Chinese speaking immigrants, of no easy solution. However, it is a question that requires further attention from both the purely theoretical and educational policy perspectives, for reasons that should be obvious, especially from the latter perspective.

One of the most important factors in better understanding the different circumstances of language learning is that of access and opportunity. In addition, the factor of access and opportunity interacts in complex ways with the above-mentioned contributing determinant of motivational disposition.

A guiding conceptual framework of our project is the following idea: that for immigrants, language learning and literacy learning are central aspects of adaptation to and integration into the receiving culture. As just alluded to above, some groups of immigrants appear to be better prepared for the required learning tasks than others. In addition, there will be significant

variation regarding access to the available learning resources for mastering the new second language, its writing system, and awareness of the learning tasks (relevant metacognitive knowledge) for each domain. A related research question of our project is to ask: what specific factors, related to language learning, contribute to successful outcomes for immigrants and how can we account for the variation in ultimate attainment from one group of immigrants to another?

Clearly related to parents' learning of the language of the receiving country is the question of how successful are their G1 children in mastering the language and literacy learning objectives, on schedule, in school? Then, to what extent do immigrants' children learn and maintain the native language of their parents? These two research problems, in turn, are ultimately related to how the multicultural population of a nation can be, or should be, conceived.

## 2 Method

### 2.1 *Contrasting Vietnamese Immigration Scenarios of Cohort 1 and Cohort 2*

The populations of interest for the current project are immigrants to Taiwan from Vietnam that happen to fall into the two categories mentioned above. In the first cohort, of the previous study (Francis & Le, 2022), all of the immigrant informants upon arrival to Taiwan immediately came to form part of a Chinese-speaking Taiwanese family. This followed in every case, without exception, because of the conditions of the resident visa – international marriage. While seemingly obvious in regard to the circumstances of the young mothers' arrival to their new country, their specific situation of immigration and family integration had important implications, we believe, for their progress in learning Chinese as a second language.

The circumstances for the second cohort, the Chinese-Vietnamese (Cantonese-speaking) immigrants, are interesting to consider as a contrast. In contrast to the international marriage cohort, the Cantonese-speaking immigrants, as political or economic refugees, largely either married another Cantonese-Vietnamese-speaking immigrant or remained single. Readers can consult the research literature on the years 1975–1980, and during subsequent periods, of exodus and displacement, and more generally on the history of the Hoa people of Vietnam (Lay, 2010; Luu et al., 2020; Yu, 2006). Among the refugee immigrants, the primary home language, initially, was either Vietnamese or Cantonese, or alternating more or less equally. For all of the interviewees of the second cohort, following the birth of the first child, speaking Mandarin Chinese at home took on added importance, if it had not done so already.

For the international marriage group, the first cohort, the onset of second language learning typically coincided with their decision to emigrate, the first lessons taken at one of residential intake centers for the prospective visa applicants in their home county while they awaited their turn.

## 2.2 *Participants in Current Study and Previous Study*

For the current study, we did not seek out the participation of new residents that satisfied a specific condition of immigration. Rather, we tried to identify a community of bilingual and multilingual immigrants from Vietnam who, in addition to Vietnamese, spoke a language/dialect of the Chinese family of languages. Participants in this second study were recruited by word-of-mouth outreach and neighborhood canvassing by the Principal Investigator in a neighborhood of Wenshan District of Taipei City known for having received resettlement of this population. Upon explanation of the objectives of the study, all potential volunteers, with one exception, agreed to participate; and the data from all volunteers were included in the study's analysis (i.e. there was no exclusion of interview data of any volunteer). Twenty-eight immigrants volunteered: 9 women and 19 men. With a median age at arrival to Taiwan of 25 (range: 12–42), interviewees looked back over the years to give an account of learning and adaptation, at median age of 56 years and 6 months at the time of the interview. Noteworthy is the detail that when asked for their preference, conversation in Vietnamese or Mandarin Chinese, all participants indicated the former.

Even though they answered a separate set of questions, the responses of the two Cantonese-speaking Vietnamese (international marriage) immigrants from the previous study were re-analyzed to be partially included in the present study for comparison purposes. The average number of Taiwanese children born to the Cantonese-Vietnamese immigrants is 2.0, only slightly higher than that of the Vietnamese international marriage immigrants at 1.7 (median number was the same, at 2).

The interview elicited both specific information (e.g., knowledge of languages, formal and informal education in Vietnam) and open-ended reflection on the experience of voyage and resettlement and new language learning in Taiwan after leaving their native country.

## 2.3 *Interview Topics for the Cantonese-Vietnamese Speakers of Cohort 2*

- (1) Family language and school language learning in Vietnam, in particular literacy learning in Vietnamese and Chinese.
- (2) Early experience living in Taiwan, overall adaptation and learning Mandarin Chinese: classes, watching/listening to programs on television

- and radio, interaction with native speakers of Mandarin. Estimate of listening and speaking ability in Mandarin Chinese and Taiyu, after 1 year, after 2 years, and so forth. Self-estimate of reading and writing ability.
- (3) How was previous knowledge of the characters, from literacy learning in Vietnam, a resource for learning to listen and speak Mandarin Chinese? In addition, we asked for observations regarding the learning of reading and writing the characters via previous instruction in Cantonese and learning to read and write the characters in Mandarin.
  - (4) Personal contacts/relationships with native Taiwanese and other immigrants in general.
  - (5) Before your children began school and during the school years, did you speak Vietnamese? Mandarin Chinese? Cantonese? Hakka? etc. And today, when you speak to your children?

What languages do you speak at home with adult family members? Have you and your family travelled back to Vietnam? What languages might or should your children and grandchildren speak as adults?

The five categories of question and prompt were selected by the project to try to gather a representative sample of observations and reflections all centered on one overarching theme – language and literacy: specifically, literacy learning in Vietnam and during the first years in Taiwan, how previous linguistic knowledge and writing from Vietnam bridged the divide. Upon arriving, how did interaction with other immigrants and native speakers of Mandarin affect progress in L2 learning; and finally, the questions about language that parents think about all the time, how do my efforts and that of my spouse, to learn the second language, affect my children?

### 3 Results

#### 3.1 *Topic 1: the Experience of Bilingual Education in Vietnam*

Participants described how until 1975, in today's southern Vietnam, public instruction included extensive Chinese-medium teaching of the academic subjects and literacy for Chinese-speaking communities as part of a bilingual curriculum. Following the anti-Chinese persecution beginning in 1975, and exacerbated by the border war with China in 1979, the officially certified bilingual schools were closed. In this regard, descriptions by informants of language learning in elementary and middle school distinguish between the previous system and the period of official cancellation, eventually ending in 1989. During the period 1975–1989, children often received their Chinese literacy

instruction after school at the homes of teachers who imparted classes on the reading and writing of characters, unofficially.

Thus, an interesting comparison in future research could be made among immigrants between:

- the generation that came of (school) age by 1973–75 that in addition may not have had the opportunity to attend after-school Chinese literacy tutoring, and
  - older immigrants who completed schooling prior to the official cancellation.
- The all-encompassing military-political upheaval of these years was the background story for interviewees. For space considerations we refer readers to relevant research literature cited above.

While Cantonese is the most widely spoken language among Chinese-Vietnamese, communities of Minnan, Hakka and Hainanese have largely preserved their mother tongue. Related to other sociolinguistic factors, Cantonese serves as the *lingua franca* for the large majority of Hoa. All 14 participants in the study whose native or family language was not Cantonese spoke Cantonese as a second Chinese language. In addition, prior to 1975, children often studied Mandarin as a L2 in one of the schools affiliated with the Republic of China's educational-cultural exchange program in collaboration with the then South Vietnamese government. Other bilingual schools followed the "Hong Kong model" which did not, on average, emphasize the learning of Mandarin to the same degree, or not at all. But as a number of participants pointed out, the Mandarin pronunciation of characters was often a part of reading lessons. In both models, *bilingual literacy*, in Vietnamese and Chinese, occupied the place of highest priority. Thus, it is not unusual for this group of immigrants to Taiwan to possess extensive multilingual abilities consisting of two or three native or near-native languages (Vietnamese, their Chinese mother-tongue, *lingua franca* Cantonese) and some L2 knowledge of Mandarin, including advanced literacy in the national language of the country, *quốc ngữ*, and in Chinese.

Participants presented a language learning panorama characterized by identification with and loyalty to the community language and its literary tradition; 27 out of 28 studied Chinese literacy either in an official Chinese-language school (17) or, after 1975, in an unofficial tutoring program (10). Regarding curricular emphasis, in the official Chinese schools, 7 attended programs with a somewhat greater emphasis on Mandarin, 5 with an emphasis on Cantonese, and 5 followed a combined approach. The unofficial tutoring programs were primarily Cantonese-based. Strong family expectation, consistently reported during interviews, ensured participation and perseverance.

The following comments are representative of parents' admonition that interviewees remembered:

Chúng mình là người Hoa mà, nên phải đọc được chữ Tàu.

We are Chinese people; we have to read the Chinese characters. (C305)

Chữ Hán là di sản của người Hoa.

The characters are the legacy of Chinese people. (C310)

Interestingly, against expectation, no measurable correlation emerged between reports of a greater emphasis on the pronunciation of characters in Mandarin and participants' estimate of listening and speaking proficiency in Mandarin upon arrival to Taiwan. It appears from descriptions of classroom and tutoring lessons that all programs included at least some content involving Mandarin pronunciation. But in general, the predominant language of instruction was Cantonese (the language that students understood and the one teacher usually spoke natively).

The major benefit for this group of immigrants from Vietnam appears to have consisted in the broad-based foundation in Chinese literacy that they received. The benefit resulted from the link that teachers forged between the characters and the language they spoke as children – Cantonese – and then to the second language, from the same linguistic family, that they were introduced to – via the characters. High integrative motivation to learn the Chinese writing system assured a significant level of mastery from participation in both the official school programs and the unofficial tutoring classes. Interestingly, most participants recalled that neither *zhuyin fuhao* nor *Hanyu pinyin* caught on in school among the students. Conceivably, the reason for this observation might be that these *phonetic-based transcribing scripts* serve most effectively those learners who are speakers of Mandarin or who are engaged in a systematic full-time Mandarin-as-L2 learning program tied to learning the characters.

Readers will note that the first category of learners that we anticipated – children who did not attend a Vietnamese-Chinese bilingual school and who did not attend tutoring class – is represented by only one interviewee, in reality an exceptional case. NT322 completed 5th grade in a Vietnamese-only school in her village and did not have the opportunity to learn the Chinese characters or study Mandarin. She began learning Mandarin and Chinese literacy upon emigrating to Taiwan at the age of 42.



### 3.2 *Topic 2: Adaptation to the New Country*

Participant accounts of language and cultural integration into the host country often pointed to a degree of continuity between the Chinese-speaking communities of Vietnam and Taiwan, and to an experienced commonality to some degree. Most immigrants from the political/economic refugee population benefitted from the issuance of a visa and received a government housing subsidy. The network of previously arriving family members and Overseas Chinese from the same communities of origin were instrumental in helping newcomers find employment. The interesting comparison with the international-marriage cohort of the previous cohort was on the self-report of socio-economic status (SES), one of significant overlap: in the great majority of cases consisting of factory work, followed by restaurant/small shop owner (3) or restaurant worker (1). The only minor contrast from the mothers of the previous cohort was that none of the immigrants of the second cohort reported the pursuit of higher education in Taiwan. Average number of grades of formal schooling completed (not counting Chinese literacy tutoring for the refugees) in the home country were also comparable: 7th grade (first cohort) and 6th grade (second cohort).

Along the dimension of language learning experience, we characterized that of the monolingual Vietnamese speakers of the first cohort as one of successful, and relatively rapid, communicative integration. While for these monolingual Vietnamese immigrants' conversational ability progressed on-schedule, literacy in Chinese generally presented for them a long-term challenge (Francis & Le, 2022). We agree with readers' anticipated observation here that the, contrasting, more rapid mastery of both Mandarin and advanced literacy by the Chinese-Vietnamese bilingual/multilingual immigrants, of the second cohort, appears as largely unremarkable as it is entirely predictable. However, aside from taking note of this difference, it is important to describe as consistently as possible the different learning outcomes of each group of immigrants to better understand the learning tasks for each one. Degree of relevant previous knowledge and other learning conditions and predispositions vary widely from one group of learners to the other among the many immigrant populations.

We call attention to the *second language literacy learning* factor under this topic of *adaptation* because as the focus of research expands to other immigrant populations there is reason to suggest the hypothesis that learning the Chinese characters will vary widely, and systematically, from one group to the next. Degrees of success on this language-literacy learning objective will vary even for L2 learners of Chinese in Taiwan who are highly literate in their L1. Successful adaptation, on average, will also vary in part as a function of the mastery of the L2 writing system, which is official and is expected for citizens.

In other words, learning to read and write the characters, we wish to emphasize as a proposal for further research, is *not optional* for full integration. Literacy in Chinese is the topic of the next subsection.

### 3.3 *Topic 3: Awareness of the Language-Literacy Connection*

Among the most consistent observations made by informants, probably the most consistent of all, were those that came under the category of language awareness, in this case the reflection on their own learning processes related to bilingualism (or multilingualism) and literacy:

- The relationship between previous knowledge of Cantonese and learning of Mandarin.
- How proficiency in reading and writing the characters, learned via Cantonese, facilitated L2 learning of Mandarin.
- Comparing and contrasting literacy learning in Cantonese and Mandarin.
- The usefulness of each of the three phonological transcribing scripts, that they had experience with, for mastering reading and writing in Chinese.

Not surprisingly, the two Cantonese-Vietnamese immigrants from the previous cohort, MG201 and VN213, showed evidence of more advanced language awareness than their international marriage peers. This awareness probably resulted from early literacy learning in their home country in two languages, and early exposure, from childhood, to both Cantonese and Mandarin in the context of learning the characters, the same bilingual and multilingual experience of the immigrants of the second cohort.

As mentioned above, literacy in Chinese was a major learning objective in the official Chinese-Vietnamese bilingual schools and the exclusive objective in the unofficial tutoring classes. Aside from learning the characters, it was in these programs where children's first academic exposure to Mandarin occurred, varying widely depending, for example, on their teacher's level of competence and the kind of textbook materials available. Then, living and working in Taiwan was where proficiency in Mandarin was perfected. Among participants who commented on how Cantonese and Mandarin are related, all remarked on what they perceived as a close relationship, even though learning the second required long-term concerted effort.

Tiếng Quảng Đông hay tiếng phổ thông, đều là ngôn ngữ của người Hoa mà.

Cantonese or Mandarin, both are our Chinese people's language. (TT308)

Là người Hoa và lại nói tiếng Quảng, chú nghĩ rất dễ để học được tiếng phổ thông.

As a Chinese person and Cantonese speaker, I think it is very easy for me to learn Mandarin. (CL304)

Knowledge of the characters allowed learners to know what the dialogue on TV shows and movies was about from the subtitles, without always understanding at first what the actors said. Pragmatic information, intonation, extralinguistic context and so forth helped learners, little by little, to focus on speech, the language itself. This learning method could be extended to understanding spoken messages in a vocational education class or other Mandarin-language context. The learner, for example, would take note of the speaker's words, transcribing the Mandarin into Vietnamese pinyin,<sup>2</sup> or with homophones, then later with the help of a friend transliterating the notation to, the correct, Chinese characters (HT309).

Recall that typically, in Vietnam, the ethnic-Chinese students received instruction in Cantonese. While report of using both Cantonese and Mandarin for learning the characters was common, it was the former that played the primary role. In all cases of Mandarin-linked literacy learning, Cantonese played an important supportive, or predominant, role. Informants recalled that as students they usually forgot Mandarin-based *hanyu pinyin* or *zhuyin fuhao* if their Vietnamese teacher actually introduced one or the other of these phonological scripts that support Chinese character learning. Logically, being that these two standard scripts for transcribing Mandarin assume a certain level of knowledge of Mandarin, neither script would have turned out to be especially useful for children who were not speakers. In the Vietnamese bilingual schools, as our informants explained, students learned primarily by memorizing and copying the characters, in line with what was known as the “Hong Kong model.” Child literacy learners in Hong Kong, today, still rely on a kind of “look-say” method of learning to read (Ho et al., 2012; Wang et al., 2018).

The remembrance of learning, after many years, appeared as particularly insightful, an example of language awareness associated with literacy. On the one hand, mastering the characters via Cantonese allowed for better

<sup>2</sup> Vietnamese pinyin is a popular informal method that second language learners of Chinese use for learning the language and the characters. Based on the official national writing script, *quốc ngữ*, it is especially productive because the tones in students' L2 Chinese can be marked consistently and accurately. As an alphabetic-phonological transcription it is part of the larger family of pinyin-type scripts in use throughout East Asia.

understanding the content: “hiểu nội dung ý nghĩa của nó sâu hơn [understand the deeper content itself]” (LK319). On the other hand, participants commented on the closer alignment between speech and writing when learning to make the proper correspondences between characters and Mandarin, years later in Taiwan. This closer relationship between speech and writing would have been noticed by immigrant learners as they came to understand and speak Mandarin more completely – we are inferring. Here, our inference should be taken as tentative given that the data of the current study (of the second cohort) is self-report testimony based on recall of a learning experience, even as this remembrance was reported consistently by virtually all of the Cantonese-speaking interviewees. See Koda (2002) and Snow (2004) for discussion of this important research question.

Specifically, the insight about learning the characters prompted the metalinguistic observation of participants that for Mandarin the language-character relationship is more systematic.

Khi mà chúng tôi học chữ Hán và nói tiếng phổ thông, chúng tôi cảm thấy nó bị ràng buộc bởi những hình thức có tính quy định hơn.

When we learned Chinese characters and speak Mandarin, we feel it is constrained more by regulated forms. (TS307)

Sử dụng tiếng phổ thông, viết gì nói đó.

Using Mandarin, writing it is like what is said. (LK319)

In contrast, learning the characters via Cantonese, informants recalled, depended more on memorization and repeated copying. On this point CH317 remarked that for this reason: “học chữ bằng tiếng Quảng thì khó hơn” [learning the characters in Cantonese is more difficult], challenge that can be overcome, as TT301 pointed out, if learners have access to books for extensive outside reading. Twenty-seven out of the 28 participants discussed the Mandarin-Cantonese/match-mismatch learning problem during the interview. Twenty-six responded consistently with an emphasis on similar issues: that aside from the advantage of using the language they understood for access to the meaning of characters, many Cantonese words do not have a corresponding character, and that the closer match between characters and their Mandarin pronunciation made learning: “hiệu quả hơn” [more efficient] (CD315). With Mandarin, there exists a greater “regularity” (HB312) in the correspondence between speech

and writing: “bởi vì nó viết thế nào thì nói thế đấy thôi” [because how it is written that is what is said] (CL304). Noticeably, in participants’ responses the (language awareness related) term “efficient” was used in the majority of comments on this question.

Expressing a different point of view, one testimony recalled that learning the characters in Cantonese versus Mandarin was “the same.” In this example (from PP203), it is interesting to note that pre-emigration Mandarin had attained an advanced level thanks in large part to literacy tutoring that placed emphasis on both languages, and by her account, because of the teacher’s effective and engaging pedagogical approach. One participant declined to comment on this question for lack of relevant experience (as a child, acquiring literacy in Vietnamese but not Chinese).

Overall, for learning the Mandarin pronunciation of characters, Vietnamese pinyin was generally the preferred choice; a large majority, 19 of 28, described its usefulness in response to questions about literacy learning: for making Sino-Vietnamese vocabulary more visible and for the awareness of tones (in addition, *chữ quốc ngữ* segments by syllable, as does *hànzi*).

The next topic returns to the theme of adaptation to the culture of the host country and inclusion into its social fabric. Related to the five topics of the Results section as a whole, the factor of adaptation and inclusion has been considered important in understanding a cultural factor: the distinction between integrative and instrumental motivation for second language learning.

### 3.4 *Topic 4: Social Integration*

Overall, the profile of the Overseas Chinese population shows itself to be, not surprisingly, one of model immigrant. In this regard, the frequent testimony, in fact somewhat more frequent than the corresponding commentary from participants of the first cohort, of unforthcoming disposition on the part of native Taiwanese, called our attention. The expectation on our part was to the contrary, considering: a shared historical culture, native languages of the same Chinese family of languages spoken by Cantonese-speaking immigrants, a more rapid mastery of Mandarin, and proficiency in a common writing system.

In particular, we expected that integrative perceptions and predispositions on the part of immigrants of the second cohort would be stronger. Notably, all immigrants interviewed for the present study, both men and women, who married (25 out of 28) with only one exception, are the spouse of another Overseas Chinese immigrant from Southeast Asia. The one exception has a Taiwanese husband. In addition, 11 participants spontaneously commented on the marriage of immigrant siblings (the interview did not include this question). Of the

29 instances mentioned, all spouses, except one, are also immigrant Overseas Chinese from Southeast Asia, usually Vietnam. During his interview, TN326, resident of Wenshan district since 1992, estimated the intra-group marriage rate at 98%.

The pattern of response on this question even prompts us to consider revisiting the issue of cultural and social integration in a larger sample corresponding to the first cohort. In particular, this factor is directly related to the two types of second language learning motivation: integrative and instrumental (Yu & Downing, 2012).

### 3.5 *Topic 5: Shift by Parents to the Language of Schooling*

All immigrant parents of the second cohort described the uptake of Mandarin Chinese in the child generation, culminating in kindergarten and first grade. Regarding expected developmental milestones for child language, parents confirmed the shift toward Mandarin as the primary language of their son or daughter. Even taking into account the small sample size of the cohort (requiring a follow-up estimate based on a larger sample), the descriptive data from parents' testimony suggests that the G1 Taiwanese children acquired Mandarin on the same schedule as native Taiwanese children.

In the case of parents who reported speaking to their pre-school age children in one of their native Vietnamese languages, almost all of them made the decision to shift to speaking with children in Mandarin at home, in large part or exclusively, as children approached or began first grade in Taiwan. Recall that by the age of school entry of their first child, immigrants had attained a high level of mastery in their second language, even as Vietnamese or Cantonese remained the stronger language. In nine families, children themselves were reported as asking their parents to make the shift, or replying in Mandarin when parents continued speaking to them in Vietnamese or Cantonese following previous custom from early childhood. This language shift scenario, interestingly, obtained even for the son of TC310 who moved back to Vietnam with his mother and became Vietnamese-Mandarin bilingual. Another immigrant parent commented:

Ba má chị không nói được tiếng phổ thông. Vì thế mà chị muốn các con học nói tiếng Quảng Đông nhưng chúng nói: “Chúng ta đang sống ở Đài Loan, nói tiếng phổ thông là đủ rồi”.

My parents cannot speak Mandarin. So, I want my children learn to speak Cantonese but they say: We are living in Taiwan, Mandarin is enough. (LS321)

In these examples, we take note of the above-mentioned “interaction between the generations” – parents making the shift to the language of school, interacting with children’s rapid acquisition of Mandarin, that in turn encourages their parents to use the language more frequently, resulting in their own more effective progress in the long run.

Indications from parents of both the previous cohort and the current cohort lead us to propose that early acquisition or later childhood learning of Vietnamese or Cantonese may also be comparable, with a possible slight advantage for G1 children from the non-refugee families. The G1 children of international-marriage families seem to have visited their maternal family in Vietnam more frequently and for longer duration on each visit than is the case for the refugee families (thus accounting for the possible advantage in the case of the former). However, it is important to point out that in both studies, from interview testimony of parents, it appears that only a minority of the first generation preserves significant competence in Vietnamese or Cantonese as children progress through the years of elementary and middle school.

#### 4 Discussion and Conclusion: Proposals for Research

The tentative results of the present study, part of the larger exploratory study on immigration and language learning, suggest the consideration of a series of hypotheses to be taken up by future fieldwork. In addition, follow-up evaluation of the study’s findings will need to apply research methods of a different kind. The exploratory study that examined participants’ self-report observations of their own learning processes opens a window for considering them for further investigation. In the first place, to validate, or confirm, these observations requires the application of a research design that includes more direct assessment methods. The preliminary results summarized above, nevertheless, allow us to present the following three hypotheses as plausible.

(1)

The bilingual Cantonese-Vietnamese speakers (including the multilingual immigrants who also speak Hakka, Minnan and Hainanese) will show the most rapid progress in language learning attaining, on average, the highest level of L2 proficiency of all Mandarin-learning immigrants. In the same manner, reading and writing ability in Chinese will attain levels *within the same distribution of that of native-born Taiwanese*. This second prediction is in line with the interesting phenomenon among learners of how L2 literacy often outstrips mastery of the L2 grammar, evidenced in speaking and listening. On



the literacy-related factor of language, or metalinguistic, awareness (related to Topics 1 and 3), the bilinguals and multilinguals of the current cohort, plus the two Cantonese-Vietnamese speakers from the previous study, as a group, gave extensive and detailed metalinguistic comments. A possible explanation for the emergence of this specific kind of awareness is that from childhood they were not only steeped in the cross-language environment of their local community but also in both Vietnamese and Chinese literacy. The bilingual literacy factor comes forward as a strong candidate explanation because the comparison between the previous study and the current study on this question had serendipitously controlled for both SES and prior educational attainment. We mention this coincidence even though it is important to clarify that the two cohorts of immigrants were not comparable in other respects. Nevertheless, we can propose that under present conditions, the Cantonese-Vietnamese cohort, together with similar immigrant populations (e.g., Overseas Chinese), may be the only immigrant population to be able to attain a level of mastery in the domain of literacy *equivalent to that of native Taiwanese*. Even from the limited data from the present study, we propose this hypothesis as plausible, to be confirmed or contradicted by a large-scale comparative assessment of reading and writing abilities (in a study that controls for age, prior educational attainment in the home country and SES).

(2)

Inter-generational language shift to Mandarin by the first-generation children of immigrants occurs almost universally, as the language of schooling and electronic media coincides with the language that in most cases effectively becomes their L1 at an early age (Topic 5). In effect, Mandarin, in this and in similar language shift scenarios, becomes children's primary language even though it may be the L2 of the parents that they rarely spoke at home prior to the birth of their first child. In addition, the shift to the national language is often accompanied by a transition away from the parents' native language. This is a difficult research question beyond the scope of the present report. From the results of self-report testimony, we can tentatively point to a complex process of *language shift* in which both parents and children themselves actively participate in response to strong over-arching influences from school, virtually all electronic media sources and language use among children's neighborhood friends and other peers.

The general phenomenon here consists in the reliable result that G1 children (in all immigrant families worldwide), if they acquire the ambient language of the host society as a L1, do not reproduce the patterns of L2 learning (e.g.,



L1->L2 transfer) of the parent generation. On this point, there is an interesting contrast to the G1 children of the previous cohort. Four of the children of the Vietnamese international marriage immigrants of the previous study learned, or at the time of the study were still learning, Chinese as a late L2. These learners, part of the larger immigrant community, belong to a subgroup that has benefitted from return visits to Vietnam for extended periods (in some cases, years), delaying the L2 development of Chinese, but as a consequence binding their L1 Vietnamese. While this subgroup probably represents a small minority, the relevant language development processes are important to examine in subsequent research.

(3)

The Overseas Chinese community from Vietnam, as a refugee population, on average, forms a more cohesive, and self-sustaining, social and cultural network than other immigrants to Taiwan, more so perhaps than other, non-refugee immigrants from Southeast Asia. Part of this hypothesis (from Topics 2 and 4) includes the possibility that the Hoa formed an especially cohesive ethnic minority community in their home country before emigration. In addition, the experience of exile passage was likely to have cemented this sensibility. TT221 shared the account of the loss at sea of his older brother and his uncle's family, while he was spared. If this factor can be shown to be described accurately, the above discussion of perceived native population antipathy might have to take note of this interactive factor; i.e., social distance and discretion ≠ hostility.

Với người Đài, chúng tôi giữ mối quan hệ như đồng nghiệp hoặc khách hàng làm ăn.

With Taiwanese local people, we keep the relationship as co-workers or customers. (NT302)

On the other hand, participants called attention to gratuitous commentary that could be evidence to the contrary:

Họ gọi chú trong tiếng Đài là “Ngọ Nản”. Thế là chú cãi nhau và hỏi lại họ: Mày đến từ đâu? Có phải tổ tiên mày cũng đến từ Trung Quốc, có đúng không? Tổ tiên của tao cũng từ Trung Quốc sang đây. Tao và mày đều là người Hoa. Thế sao mày gọi tao là ‘Ngọ Nản’ với một thái độ phân biệt chủng tộc thế?

They call me in Taiyu “Ngoa Nan (Vietnamese guy)”. Then I argued and questioned them: Where are you from? Your previous generations were from China, right? My ancestral family was also from China. We are both Chinese people. Why do you call me “Ngoa Nan” with discriminatory intention? (C326)

Họ vẫn xem chúng tôi như công dân thứ hai. Mặc dù chúng tôi đều là người Hán từ Trung Quốc sang, thế mà họ gọi tôi là cái thằng Việt Nam.

People call me Vietnamese guy, even though we are all Han people from China. But they look at us as second citizen. (C309, who remarked that “he cannot socialize in Taiwan society”)

The following questions for future research will complement the examination of hypotheses (1) (2) and (3).

(4)

The highly reliable observations by the second language learners in regard to the difference between learning the characters via Cantonese and via Mandarin, in favor of the latter in terms of regularity, consistency and alignment of speech↔script, was one of the most noteworthy results of the interviews. It was especially so in light of the also reliable recollection of how, as young students, teachers’ use of Cantonese as the primary language of literacy learning helped them make the link more easily to meaning. In addition, the participants’ language awareness related observations happen to coincide with an important discussion among researchers on the question of the language-orthography interface; see the study by Anderson et al. (2003) comparing performance of Mandarin and Cantonese-speaking children on different measures of reading. At the same time, it is important to keep in mind that, while strongly relevant and suggestive, the self-report data needs to be corroborated (or relativized, or disconfirmed) by further direct assessment of performance in a systematic comparison of learners of different languages or dialects, as in the study cited in this section. We cannot say at this time that our findings, as interesting as they appear to be, can be taken as direct evidence that favor one hypothesis or another.

(5)

The present pilot study points to interesting aspects of the so-called “immigrant effect” for G1 and new-comer child populations (Kaufman, 2004) as it might significantly impact their motivation for learning and academic achievement in

general. The Kaufman study compared immigrant and nonimmigrant Chinese-speaking students in the United States. A comparison involving first generation children in Taiwan could study the experience of immigrant and nonimmigrant children all immersed into a Chinese-speaking culture.

(6)

Studies of L2 learning involving an L1 and L2 from the same Chinese linguistic family are relatively scarce, perhaps because the learning processes are taken for granted – on the one hand – or due to controversies associated with government language policy (Hong Kong, Singapore, and to a lesser extent Taiwan) – on the other hand. Consider, for example, reviews of the debate specifically on language in education policy in Hong Kong from the previous decade by Tam (2011) and Evans (2013). The controversies on the official and unofficial uses of Cantonese and Mandarin have only become sharper (Liu, 2017), even becoming highly politicized in recent years. The continued study of the learning experience of Overseas Chinese immigrants as they learn a second Chinese dialect/language is nevertheless important as a contribution to the field of Second Language Acquisition (SLA). A related scientific question in SLA alluded to in our study is the often sensitive (but important to better understand) question of concomitant language shift – language attrition or replacement – that primarily affects first generation child learners. Ding (2016) is an especially compelling report on this question taking the example of the diaspora of Hokkien-speaking communities. Readers will note that this last proposal for further study is related to Hypothesis #2 above. As alluded to, the comparative study of the different G1 child populations on the question of the preservation of their parents' language(s) – Vietnamese, Cantonese, Indonesian, and so forth – presents itself as an important research opportunity.

Future work in this area will help us better understand the variation in L2 learning of the national language from one group of immigrants to another and the related development of language awareness. The research advances on the question of how language learning is related to social integration should contribute to the design of the most effective language learning policies that in the end are the responsibility of the nation as a whole. The importance of continuing work on this concept by language specialists, and on the application of policies that follow from it, of course, also applies to the population of children of immigrants who are also L2 learners of Chinese. What factors account for the difference between successful and unsuccessful scenarios in language learning as it is related to social integration? This question applies to both immigrant parents and to their first-generation sons and daughters.

### Conflict of Interest

There are no conflicts of interest associated with this project to report.

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